'enormously' to strengthen relations with former UF leaders who had fallen out of favour with Karzai, and were getting increasingly disillusioned by India.[91] The Massoud family, Mohaqiq, Dostum, and other second-tier Afghan politicians from north, west, and central Afghanistan, all began engaging with Pakistan.[92] Wali Massoud admitted that a Pakistan's delegation visited him in April 2013 and wanted him to 'meet the head of the ISI in whichever part of the world' he liked. They asked him why are they were fighting each other when they could be friends. 'They [Pakistan] come with logic', noted Wali Massoud.[93] Similar to India that used its higher-education scholarships as a tool of coopting the Afghan political elite (by offering their children or relatives opportunities to study in Indian universities), Pakistan offered scholarships to former UF leaders (classic tit-for-tat).[94]

In May 2013, Ahmad Zia Massoud, former Afghan vice president and leader of the National Front Party, openly criticised Karzai's focus on the Durand Line and ramping up the Pashtun rhetoric with Pakistan:

> By benefiting from such national issues, the President wants to stir people's support in favour of his favourable candidate in the forthcoming polls ... This, in no way, will be the solution to solve our complicated border issue with the neighbouring countries through the media and stimulation of public emotions and sentiments. It could be solved through logical diplomatic dialogues.[95]

Not just non-Pashtun leaders, even Hanif Atmar, a senior Pashtun leader and current national security advisor of Afghanistan, believed, at least in 2013, that 'one big mistake that Afghanistan did was the signing of the SPA first with India rather than with Pakistan. Islamabad had offered us an SPA before India did but we refused to sign it.' Being a bigger power in the region, New Delhi would have understood Kabul's logic of engaging with Pakistan, Atmar argued.[96] Atmar launched a spectacular diplomatic initiative to reconcile differences with Pakistan with support from current Afghan president Ashraf Ghani in 2014. The consistency with which Pakistan intervened in Afghan affairs had made it a loathed, dreaded, hated, but also, ironically, an awe-inspiring neighbour in Afghanistan. In contrast, India's image of a reluctant and indecisive regional power bode ill for New Delhi's quest for broad-basing political relationships in Afghanistan.